

Chapter

Food for Nourishment, Not for Harm



Introduction: When Everything Is "I"

What we should and should not eat is not only a question of taste or health; it is also a question of sadhana. In this short discourse Acharya Upendra Ji explains non-violence and vegetarianism not as a rule, but from the **standpoint of moksha**. He begins right here:

"If moksha is the goal, then it will be impossible for me to kill others. Because do I ever feel like cutting off a part of my own body? Should I cut off my own limb?"

A seeker who longs for liberation knows that nothing in creation is separate from them. Acharya Ji makes this clear:

"So when I see that 'All is God' — God is me, I am That — then everything, in and through, is that Supreme Lord. So I do not want to eat a part of myself, and I will not want to kill it."

When the same Supreme Lord is seen in every being, killing anyone becomes like cutting off one's own limb.

1. The Example of the Fingernail: What Grows Back

Is every act of cutting, then, violence? Acharya Ji gives the example of his own body:

"If I consider myself, I am one whole. So if a fingernail is extra material, don't I cut it myself? It doesn't even hurt me. Even if it does, no tension, a new one comes back."

"A new one comes back, doesn't it? That is why we are able to cut it. If you were told to cut off a finger, how many people would do it?"

There is a subtle distinction here: **cutting a nail is easy, because it grows back; no one agrees to cut off a finger, because it does not come back.**

2. The Secret of Offering Hair at the Temple

Acharya Ji connects this same distinction to the hair offering made at India's great temples:

"Those big temples, you know, they say 'cut your hair.'
'We went and offered our hair.' So offering hair meant offering one's desires and cravings, handing them over to God."

The inner meaning of offering hair is **to surrender one's desires and cravings to God.** And why do people do it so readily?

"They can give so much hair precisely because hair is capital that keeps growing — cut as much as you like, new hair is going to come back."

(**Bhandaval** — the Marathi word he uses, meaning capital.)

Then he asks us to imagine:

"Just by mistake, announce that you have to cut off this small a piece of your finger and offer it. How many people will go to the temple? Tell me. Announce from tomorrow that only then will God be pleased — how many people will go? Because they know it is supposed to grow back."

3. What Is Violence and What Is Not

Now Acharya Ji puts forward the test of violence:

"So a part of me, which does not hurt even when broken off, or the pain is negligible, and which is going to grow back — if I offer such a thing, can I call that violence?"

"'Oh, how much hair he is cutting, what hair-violence!' — really? Think about it and tell me."

The example of sweat makes it even simpler:

"If I collected my sweat and kept it, gave it to someone or threw it away, would I feel sorrow about that sweat? Because a new one is going to come back anyway. So what difference does it make? This is not called violence. But if a limb of mine is broken off, or I myself am killed, that is violence."

The test is this: taking what can be given without pain and that grows again is not violence; breaking off a limb or taking a life itself is violence.

4. Why Vegetarian Food?

By this same test Acharya Ji explains the reason for vegetarianism:

"Do you know why vegetarian food is acceptable? Because only that part of the tree or plant in which fruits and flowers come is plucked, so that the whole tree is not broken. That part comes back from it."

"In it the senses, or sensation, will be very little; in it the prana-energy remains for a long time; and it does not bring a curse."

Fruits, flowers and greens are like the nails and hair of a tree — **they are taken, but the tree stays alive and they grow again.** Their sensation is very slight, their life-energy lasts long, and taking them brings no curse.

5. The Promise of Goddess Shakambhari

Finally, Acharya Ji points to the scriptures:

"In the scriptures the Devi says — 'I will come as the Shakambhari Shakti, and you will have to eat only greens (shaak); your food will be greens.' Vegetarian food was made so clear to human beings; that is why this is said."

This promise of the Devi appears in the Durga Saptashati (Devi Mahatmya), where, in a time of famine, the Goddess vows to sustain the world with greens born of her own body:

**tato'ham akhilaṁ lokam ātma-deha-
samudbhavaḥ
bhariṣyāmi surāḥ śākair āvṛṣṭeḥ prāṇa-dhāraṇaiḥ
śākambharīti vikhyātiṁ tadā yāsyāmy ahaṁ
bhuvi**

"Then, O gods, until the rains come, I shall nourish the whole world with life-sustaining greens born of my own body, and I shall then become renowned on earth as Shakambhari."

— Durga Saptashati 11.48–49

Greens are food given by the Goddess herself.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1** A seeker of moksha cannot kill anyone — when one sees "All is God," every being is one's own limb.
- 2** Giving or taking what grows back is not violence — like nails, hair and sweat.
- 3** Offering hair means offering one's desires and cravings to God.
- 4** Breaking off a limb or taking a life is what violence is.
- 5** Vegetarian food is right because taking fruits, flowers and greens does not break the tree, they grow again, their sensation is slight and their prana-energy great, and no curse comes with them.
- 6** The promise of Goddess Shakambhari — the food of human beings should be greens.